

Chapter 5 - Divine Soul

The soft sensation lasted only an instant before turning cold.

"Stinking brat, are you trying to tire your mother to death!"

A clear female voice rang out. Ning Fuyi's eyes suddenly regained their sight, and she looked toward an endless expanse of grass where a young woman was holding a round-faced little girl, loudly scolding her.

"Fly, fly, fly fly fly fly..." Six-year-old Ning Fuyi paid no heed to the woman's anger, still stretching out her short arms, fluttering like a bird.

"What kind of sin did I commit to give birth to such a little demon!" Ning Changfeng's eyes almost rolled to the back of her head. She threw Ning Fuyi to the ground and wiped the sweat from her forehead, completely abandoning her sect master dignity.

"What a waste of my unparalleled foundation and talent—the child turned out to be an idiot! Normal cultivator children have some immortal power by age six, but you can't even speak properly!" Ning Changfeng stood with arms akimbo, cursing loudly.

Six-year-old Ning Fuyi didn't understand why she was being yelled at. She bit her finger with teary eyes, feeling wronged for a moment, then forgot about it and started reaching toward the sky again: "Fly fly fly..."

"Fly fly fly your head!" Ning Changfeng said irritably. In the end, she couldn't resist Ning Fuyi's persistence, bent down, and hoisted her onto her shoulders.

"Where do you want to fly this time?"

Ning Fuyi grinned, showing a mouthful of scattered teeth, and pointed toward the distant east.

"Damn it, pick another direction! If we keep flying, we'll fly out of the Eight Wastelands¹!"

"Fly!"

...

The scene before her eyes gradually became covered with mist. Ning Fuyi suddenly opened her eyes, breathing rapidly, her eyes somewhat moist.

She stared at the ceiling painted with colorful patterns, quickly wiping away her tears, and alertly tried to get up. However, two soft hands reached out from beside her, supporting her arms and helping her sit up.

Looking up, she saw Liu Wenzhu gazing at her with concern: "Yiyi, are you still feeling unwell?"

Ning Fuyi was stunned for a moment, then quickly looked around. She was in a spacious room filled with swirling incense. Red wooden beds were arranged on both sides of the room, each separated by screens. Outside the window, it was already night, so quiet that only the still mountain shadows were visible.

This was the sleeping hall where disciples rested.

She had crashed into Chu Qingqiu's arms, hadn't she? How did she end up lying here? Could it be that Chu Qingqiu had brought her...

As if sensing her confusion, Liu Wenzhu gently explained: "You suddenly ran out of Cloud Deep Hall earlier. I was worried about your health and followed you. It's good I did, or you might still be lying on the mountaintop."

...

Indeed, she had been presumptuous. How could someone like Chu Qingqiu be willing to bring her back?

She wouldn't even help her turn over.

Ning Fuyi rolled her eyes internally, then looked down at herself.

The pain in her body had disappeared, and her immortal power seemed to have recovered somewhat. Though still incomparable to others, it was much better than the near-exhaustion she'd experienced before.

After her rebirth, all of Chu Qingqiu's behaviors were different from her previous life, so she had suddenly formed a hypothesis earlier. However, after fainting once, she felt such speculation was quite absurd and didn't know how to ask without arousing Chu Qingqiu's suspicion.

Never mind, since that was the case, she could ask later.

"Where are the others? There's no need for cultivation today—where did they all go?" Ning Fuyi suddenly remembered something and asked with a frown.

Liu Wenzhu's expression flashed with embarrassment. Those autumn-water eyes looked down for a while before she answered with determination: "Yiyi, the Sect Master passed away due to qi deviation², so her divine soul is shattered and difficult to reincarnate."

"So at this hour, everyone should be gathered outside the ancestral hall, waiting to help restore the Sect Master's divine soul."

Restoring the divine soul... A surge of anger rose in Ning Fuyi's heart. She suddenly stood up, but her vision was once again shrouded in black mist. She quickly grabbed the screen to steady herself.

"Yiyi!" Liu Wenzhu anxiously blocked her path and supported her. "I was afraid your body couldn't handle it, so I listened to Elder Pingyao and didn't tell you."

"Restoring the divine soul requires a blood relative to serve as guardian. If I'm not there, who else would..."

Halfway through her words, Ning Fuyi stopped, then her words turned into a knowing cold laugh.

If she wasn't there, naturally someone else would be. Even if she were there, the one serving as guardian for her mother might not necessarily be her.

"Li Chaoan?" Ning Fuyi raised an eyebrow.

Liu Wenzhu knew that Ning Fuyi and Li Chaoan never got along, so she could only nod.

How did Ning Fuyi know? Because in her previous life, it was Li Chaoan who had served as guardian for Ning Changfeng's soul restoration. Everyone felt that Li Chaoan should be the one to serve as guardian for Ning Changfeng.

Why? Because Ning Fuyi was the biological daughter, while Li Chaoan was the adopted daughter. Ning Fuyi was a waste, while Li Chaoan was a genius.

Li Chaoan was brought back when Ning Fuyi had finally learned to speak. At that time, Ning Fuyi was already about ten years old, still looking like a child physically, but her mind was already clear as a mirror. She knew that almost everyone in the sect, except for her mother, thought she would be a foolish idiot for life.

Perhaps her mother thought the same way too, but she never said so. She would only grab Ning Fuyi by the ears and scold her for spilling food.

But Li Chaoan was different. She was the daughter of Ning Changfeng's childhood friend, born with five-colored auspicious light, possessed immortal meridians at age one, reached the Initial Realm at three, and broke through to the Mortal Realm by ten.

She was also likeable in appearance—big eyes and a cherry mouth. After arriving at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, she won the affection of all elders and senior disciples. The disciples privately said that the Sect Master brought Li Chaoan back to the mountain gate to cultivate the next sect master.

After all, if the biological daughter was useless, they had to train a new one.

"Wenzhu, I want to go to the ancestral hall." Ning Fuyi suddenly said to Liu Wenzhu. Her eyes still held some tears, crystalline against her eyelashes.

"I want to see Ning Changfeng. Will you take me there?"

Night deepened like congealed ink that no amount of candlelight could dispel.

Liu Wenzhu wasn't qualified to enter the ancestral hall. Ning Fuyi walked alone through the crowd of disciples who were bowing their heads in silent mourning, standing outside the ancestral hall and looking up at the plaque above.

Four large characters were carved on the plaque: "One Life's End³."

This name was chosen by Ning Changfeng and written in her own hand. The four characters were written messily and quite ugly.

Besides the ancestral hall, other places in Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, such as the sleeping quarters called "Sleep of No Return" and the toilet named "Thousand Li Flow," were also written by Ning Changfeng herself. The better-sounding names like Cloud Deep Hall were specially requested from Chu Qingqiu at Purple Cloud Peak by the four chief elders who couldn't bear it anymore.

Others could name them too, but Ning Changfeng wouldn't use names chosen by others.

Today seemed to require many memories. Too many forgotten memories kept appearing in her mind, giving Ning Fuyi a headache. She pressed her index finger to her temple and resolutely stepped inside.

The ancestral hall was very large, large enough to accommodate all the disciples, and very high—you couldn't see the head of the stone statue in the center even when looking up. Now it was empty, with the elders nowhere to be seen.

A transparent ice coffin was now placed in the center of the ancestral hall, emitting wisps of cold air. Ning Fuyi naturally knew what was inside. She walked forward with urgent steps.

The coffin was filled with blooming gardenias. A woman in gorgeous robes lay within, as if peacefully sleeping, with cold and stern features that bore seven parts resemblance to Ning Fuyi.

The three parts that were different were three parts less wicked.

"Ning Changfeng." Ning Fuyi murmured, reaching out to touch her mother's face. Suddenly, a harsh wind blew from one side, striking her hand away and leaving a deep red mark on her pale wrist.

"What are you doing!" A delicate shout rang out, followed by the sound of many footsteps. Ning Fuyi covered her wrist and turned around, the tremendous killing intent in her heart surging forth, making her vision somewhat dizzy.

Walking at the front was a bright-eyed, beautiful young girl. Her long black hair was tied into several bundles and secured with a flower crown. Her dress was as bright as spring blooming in sunlight.

"Li Chaoan." Ning Fuyi said each word distinctly, slowly turning around.

Many people had come, all familiar faces—mostly sect elders and high-ranking inner disciples, all looking grave as they stood before Ning Fuyi.

Outside the crowd stood a white figure. Ning Fuyi glanced in that direction.

"Fuyi, what are you doing here?" Elder Pingyao stepped forward reproachfully.

"This is my mother—can't I even touch her?" Ning Fuyi ignored Pingyao, first speaking to Li Chaoan, then turning to Elder Pingyao. "I came here naturally to see my mother off."

"Adoptive mother's divine soul is already incomplete. Who knows if your clumsy hands might scatter what remains!" Li Chaoan said sharply. She pushed past Ning Fuyi and positioned herself between Ning Fuyi and the ice coffin.

Ning Fuyi clenched her fists.

"Enough." Elder Pingyao sternly interrupted them both. "Fuyi, you go out first. After we gather the Sect Master's divine soul, it won't be too late to bid farewell to the Sect Master."

"What if I refuse?" Ning Fuyi said quietly. "The one lying in the coffin is my biological mother, not Li Chaoan's. Naturally, I should be the one to serve as guardian."

"Just you?" Li Chaoan looked Ning Fuyi up and down disdainfully. "With your cultivation level, how are you qualified to serve as guardian for adoptive mother?"

"Being a guardian only requires blood, not cultivation level." Ning Fuyi didn't yield an inch. "With your status, how are you qualified to serve as guardian for my mother?"

She emphasized the words "my mother" heavily, leaving Li Chaoan speechless and making her face turn red.

"Fuyi, Chaoan is right. Your cultivation is too low. If something goes wrong, it would cause even more trouble. Let Chaoan handle it." Another middle-aged male elder spoke up.

"Yes, even setting aside cultivation, your current physical condition probably can't support it. Besides, the Sect Master always doted on Chaoan. Having her serve as guardian should satisfy the Sect Master too." Another inner disciple tried to persuade her.

One after another, they spoke, making the murderous intent in Ning Fuyi's heart grow stronger, like a fire burning inside her body, ready to explode at any moment.

Though Ning Fuyi lacked talent, she had always been protected by Ning Changfeng and never needed to bow to anyone. Only Ning Changfeng could make her willingly bend her spine.

Like in her previous life, when no one allowed her to serve as guardian, she had knelt outside Chu Qingqiu's door for a night and day, sobbing blood as she begged, just to see Ning Changfeng's soul one last time.

Back then, she thought she was worthless, so that's what she deserved.

But now she was no longer that Ning Fuyi who hadn't experienced wind and rain. She feared nothing and begged no one.

"Chaoan, don't waste any more time." The male elder glanced at the time and waved his hand. The Eternal Lamp⁴ rose into the air and landed in Li Chaoan's hands.

The Eternal Lamp was a divine artifact of the immortal realm. There was only one in the world, stored at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. It was said this lamp could burn for thirty thousand years without extinguishing, able to communicate with heaven and earth, seeking the souls of the deceased and gathering them at the lamp's wick for salvation.

Li Chaoan looked at Ning Fuyi smugly. Her left hand gripped the Eternal Lamp while her right hand was about to draw blood. Suddenly, she heard something piercing through the air, and her wrist felt sticky.

She looked down and couldn't help letting out a piercing scream. Instinctively swinging her hand forcefully, she nearly flung the Eternal Lamp away, startling Elder Pingyao beside her, who quickly summoned immortal power to retrieve the lamp.

"What is that thing!" Li Chaoan was so frightened her face turned pale. Her right hand waved frantically in the air, but the sticky thing on her wrist seemed to have burrowed into her skin and couldn't be shaken off no matter what.

The elders nearby didn't know what had happened and could only look at each other, with no one acting. Finally, an inner disciple pointed at Li Chaoan's wrist and cried out: "What is that?"

"No good, it's a parasitic worm⁵!" The male elder was shocked and reached out to remove it, but was stopped by Elder Pingyao.

"Wait, parasitic arts are sinister. Don't act rashly." She angrily looked up, searching. "Parasitic arts are forbidden techniques—who dares to be so bold!"

A laugh came from the side. Several people's gazes shook, looking in disbelief at Ning Fuyi, who was curling her slender fingers with no trace of laughter in her eyes.

"Fuyi! Do you know the Sect Master ordered that parasitic arts not be practiced? Moreover, today the Sect Master's immortal body is still here—stop this nonsense!" Elder Pingyao's face turned red with anger as she sternly rebuked.

The young girl stood straight, her slightly curved lips giving her a somewhat sinister appearance. She didn't look at Elder Pingyao but fixed her gaze on Li Chaoan, who was crying like rain. Her finger moved slightly, and the long, sticky parasitic worm suddenly raised its head, poised to burrow into Li Chaoan's skin.

Though Li Chaoan was a cultivation genius, she was most afraid of insects, let alone disgusting parasitic worms. She immediately stiffened and screamed, as if about to faint.

Seeing her in this state, Ning Fuyi felt a surge of satisfaction.

"I don't care how high her cultivation is, nor do I care how Ning Changfeng treated her. How can my mother's soul be touched by an outsider?" Ning Fuyi said lightly, flicking her fingertips. The firelight cast light and shadow on her face, radiating dangerous energy.

Though Ning Fuyi had always been idle and unskilled, she had never shown such sharp edges. Everyone was shocked to see her like this.

"My mother can only have me as her guardian." Ning Fuyi spoke again, her voice low with obsession.

She had lost too much and was used to losing, which had developed this obsessive character. Whatever she wanted to obtain, regardless of the situation or cost, she didn't care.

Though she now lacked demonic power, having been a demon lord for hundreds of years, she could still manage some illusions and minor tricks to deceive people.

Dealing with Li Chaoan was more than enough.

"Ning Fuyi, how dare you!" The male elder beside them, being Li Chaoan's master, couldn't bear to see Li Chaoan suffer such torment. Unable to contain his anger, he raised his hand and summoned a cold light.

Elder Pingyao couldn't stop him in time. Seeing the cold light heading straight for Ning Fuyi's face, everyone gasped.

Ning Fuyi had expected this scene. She didn't even bother to put away her smile, just tilted her head slightly, preparing to take the punishment head-on.

Footnotes:

¹ **Eight Wastelands (八荒)** - Refers to the eight directions/regions of the world, essentially meaning "everywhere" or "the entire world."

² **Qi deviation (走火入魔)** - A dangerous condition in cultivation where a cultivator's spiritual energy goes haywire, often leading to madness, serious injury, or death.

³ **One Life's End (一命呜呼)** - A classical Chinese expression meaning "to die" or "one's life comes to an end." It's typically used in a somewhat humorous or irreverent way, which fits Ning Changfeng's personality.

⁴ **Eternal Lamp (长生灯)** - A mystical lamp that can burn for extremely long periods and is used in spiritual/religious ceremonies, particularly for communicating with souls of the deceased.

⁵ **Parasitic worm (蛊虫)** - In Chinese folklore and cultivation fiction, these are mystical insects used in parasitic arts (蛊术), a form of black magic involving the control of specially cultivated poisonous insects or worms.